My political struggle and argument is that we should not only vote but contest elections so that democracy is strengthened, and the reality of our Indian democracy is that if you don't have a political voice then your issues of development and education won't be taken forward. This is the crass reality and to prove that [see] Sachar Committee, Mishra Commission, Kundu Committee, NSSO data. Wherever you have a semblance of political representation, all these parameters improve.

Since 2014, the BJP's rise and the Congress's shrinkage has certainly created the political space for a party that represents 'Muslim' interests in a way that existing 'secular' parties do not. This became evident as early as 2009, when the Peace Party in UP, founded by the surgeon Dr Mohammad Ayub, set itself up as precisely such a vehicle for Muslim and Dalit interests. It ended up winning significant vote shares (8–12 per cent) in four Lok Sabha constituencies in the state: Gonda, Domariyaganj, Basti and Sant Kabir Nagar.[41] The Peace Party, which also won four MLAs in the 2012 UP assembly polls, later faded away. It is this breach that AIMIM sought to fill as it expanded outside of Hyderabad.

Owaisi himself was aligned with the Congress till 2012. He famously voted in favour of Manmohan Singh's Indo-US nuclear deal in Parliament in 2008 after the then UP chief minister, BSP's Mayawati, declared that Indian Muslims were against the deal.[42] Owaisi had stated in Parliament then that he was voting to save the Congress-led government, specifically to pre-empt the possibility of a BJP government coming to power.[43] Yet, he ended a fourteen-year alliance with the Congress—at the national as well as state level—in 2012, citing the 'communal policies' of the then Congress government in Andhra Pradesh.[44] Did he worry about being pigeonholed by his opponents and reduced to a stereotype, I asked him. 'What really bothers me is this language of Congress party wherein they don't want, in real terms, a political leadership to develop of weaker sections, which includes Muslims,' he responded with a barely concealed smirk and twinkle in his eye. 'This is the mentality of Congress Party. If you oppose them, you become